

The Merchant of Venice

Act 1, Scene 3 • Comprehensive Study Guide

🕒 Standard: **ICSE Literature**

🔍 Focus: **The Bond Scene**

🛡️ Target: **Board Exams**

Reference to Context (RTC)

PART I**SHYLOCK (Aside)**

*"I hate him for he is a Christian,
But more for that in low simplicity
He lends out money gratis and brings down
The rate of usance here in Venice.
If I can catch him once upon the hip,
I will feed fat the ancient grudge I bear him."*

a) Who is speaking these lines and to whom?

Shylock speaks these lines in an **aside**. He is speaking directly to the audience, expressing his internal thoughts, about Antonio.

b) Why does Shylock hate Antonio? Give two reasons.

Shylock hates Antonio because:

1. **Religious Hostility:** Antonio is a Christian, and Shylock feels deep-seated religious hostility towards Christians.
2. **Economic Harm:** Antonio lends money without charging interest ("gratis"), which damages Shylock's own moneylending business by lowering usury rates in Venice.

c) Explain the phrases: "catch him once upon the hip" & "feed fat the ancient grudge".

- **“catch him once upon the hip”**: A metaphor derived from wrestling, meaning to gain a physical or strategic advantage over someone, rendering them helpless.
- **“feed fat the ancient grudge”**: A graphic expression meaning to fully satisfy and satisfy his long-standing, deep hatred and desire for revenge.

d) What does this extract reveal about Shylock's character?

The extract reveals Shylock to be **revengeful, bitter, calculating, deeply prejudiced**, and **economically competitive**. It highlights that he is willing to wear a polite business mask while harboring deadly schemes.

\$ Deeper Analysis

This extract is extremely important because it exposes Shylock's true motive behind the bond. While he outwardly behaves like a businessman, inwardly he is driven by resentment and revenge. The phrase “ancient grudge” suggests that the hatred between Antonio and Shylock has existed for a long time. Shakespeare uses this moment to establish the emotional foundation for the later trial scene.

ANTONIO

*"The devil can cite Scripture for his purpose!
An evil soul producing holy witness
Is like a villain with a smiling cheek,
A goodly apple rotten at the heart."*

a) On what occasion does Antonio say these lines?

Antonio says these lines after Shylock uses the Biblical story of **Jacob and Laban** to justify charging interest on loans, framing usury as a blessed endeavor.

b) What literary devices are used in these lines?

The following literary devices are used here:

- **Simile:** Comparing a hypocritical evil soul to "a villain with a smiling cheek".
- **Metaphor:** Describing Shylock's deceitful nature as "a goodly apple rotten at the heart".
- **Biblical Allusion:** Pointing out that "the devil can cite Scripture".
- **Imagery:** Contrast between appealing visuals (smiling cheek, goodly apple) and inner decay.

c) What does this reveal about Antonio's attitude towards Shylock?

Antonio believes that Shylock is fundamentally **hypocritical**, **corrupt**, and **dishonest**. He views Shylock's reliance on religious anecdotes as a cynical attempt to justify greed.

d) Explain the dramatic irony in this extract.

Although Antonio clearly recognizes Shylock's potential for hypocrisy and villainy ("smiling cheek"), he still ignores his own warning and signs Shylock's dangerous bond. The audience knows Shylock is planning harm, making Antonio's complacency highly ironical.

\$ Deeper Analysis

The comparison of Shylock to "a goodly apple rotten at the heart" reflects the theme of appearance versus reality. Shakespeare repeatedly shows characters who appear kind or noble externally but hide dangerous motives internally. Antonio's statement also reflects the religious prejudice of the time, where Jews were often viewed suspiciously by Christians.

SHYLOCK & BASSANIO

SHYLOCK: *"This is kind I offer."*

BASSANIO: *"This were kindness!"*

SHYLOCK: *"Go with me to a notary, seal me there*

Your single bond; and, in a merry sport,

If you repay me not on such a day...

let the forfeit

Be nominated for an equal pound

Of your fair flesh..."

a) Why does Shylock call the bond a “merry sport”?

Shylock uses the phrase “**merry sport**” to disarm Antonio and Bassanio, making a deadly demand sound like a harmless, humorous game. This prevents them from suspecting his murderous intentions.

b) Why does Bassanio object to the bond?

Bassanio instinctively distrusts Shylock. He warns Antonio: *"I like not fair terms and a villain's mind."* He values his friend's life over his own financial convenience.

c) Why does Antonio readily agree?

Antonio is **excessively confident** that his merchant fleets will return safely. He expects to make nine times the bond value a full month before the expiration date.

d) How does this extract advance the plot?

This extract initiates the central conflict of the play: the "**pound of flesh**" bond. The signing of this contract creates the primary driver for all future conflicts and trials.

Short Answer Questions

PART II

Q1. Why does Shylock call the bond a “merry bond”?

Shylock describes the agreement as a “**merry bond**” or “**merry sport**” to make the extreme condition (a pound of flesh) seem lighthearted and non-serious. This is a deliberate tactic to mask his deep desire for revenge under the cover of a friendly joke.

Q2. How does Shylock justify charging interest on loans?

Shylock references the Old Testament story of **Jacob and Laban**. He explains that Jacob used his intelligence to increase his flock of sheep, which was blessed by God. Shylock equates this to the generation of interest, claiming that *"thrift is blessing, if men steal it not."*

Q3. Why does Bassanio object to the bond while Antonio agrees?

Bassanio's survival is not at risk; his friend's is. He is cautious and detects Shylock's underlying malice, saying he doesn't trust "fair terms and a villain's mind." Antonio, blinded by overconfidence in his commercial success and his loyalty to Bassanio, dismisses all risks, believing his ships will return in time.

Q4. What does Shylock mean by “suffrance is the badge of all our tribe”?

Shylock is highlighting the historical persecution and discrimination faced by the Jewish community in Venice. “**Suffrance**” (endurance/patient suffering) is portrayed as a necessary trait ("badge") worn by Jews to survive ongoing social insults, abuses, and exclusion.

Q5. What risks threaten Antonio’s business ventures?

Shylock lists these risks during their meeting:

- **Physical Dangers:** Storms, shallow waters, destructive rocks.
- **Human Threats:** Pirates ("land-thieves and water-thieves").
- **Geographical Spread:** Ships scattered widely to Tripoli, the Indies, Mexico, and England, making his assets highly volatile.

Q6. What does Antonio’s behaviour reveal about his personality?

Antonio's behaviors showcase key paradoxes:

- **Generous & Loyal:** Willing to pledge his life for his friend Bassanio.
- **Arrogant & Prejudiced:** Boldly admits to spitting on Shylock and asserts he would do so again.
- **Tragically Overconfident:** Underestimates Shylock and refuses to take warnings seriously.

Long Answer / Essay Questions

PART III

Q1. Describe Shylock's attitude towards Antonio in this scene.

Shylock's attitude towards Antonio is a complex mix of deep personal hatred, religious conflict, and calculated greed. This hostility is driven by three main factors:

- **Religious Hostility:** Shylock declares in an aside, "*I hate him for he is a Christian.*" The conflict represents a larger historical divide between Venice's Christian majority and Jewish minority.
- **Economic Damage:** Antonio hurts Shylock's business by lending money without interest ("gratis"), lowering the interest rates across Venice and directly reducing Shylock's profits.
- **Personal Humiliation:** Shylock details how Antonio has repeatedly insulted him on the Rialto, calling him a "misbeliever, cut-throat dog," and spitting upon his Jewish garments.

Despite this anger, Shylock masks his feelings, adopting a polite business tone. His statement "*If I can catch him once upon the hip, I will feed fat the ancient grudge I bear him*" reveals his deliberate plan to trap Antonio using the bond.

Q2. Bring out the contrast between Antonio and Shylock.

Antonio and Shylock are set up as foils to highlight the play's core conflicts. Here is a comparison of their values:

Aspect	Antonio	Shylock
Religion	Christian (Dominant group)	Jew (Persecuted minority)
Attitude to Money	Lends gratis (without interest)	Practices usury (charges interest)
Personality	Generous, open, loyal to friends	Cautious, defensive, calculated
Behavior	Proud, blunt, sometimes arrogant	Polite facade, patient, resentful
Motive	Friendship and self-sacrifice	Financial profit and revenge
Language	Direct, poetic, emotional	Sharp, business-like, sarcastic

Antonio represents Christian charity, but his generosity is marred by his prejudice and harsh treatment of Shylock. Conversely, Shylock's cruelty is driven by years of systemic exclusion and personal insults. Shakespeare presents both characters with flaws, avoiding a simple good vs. evil narrative.

Q3. How does this scene prepare the ground for future conflict?

Act 1, Scene 3 sets up the main conflict of the play through several key elements:

- **The Core Conflict:** The signing of the "pound of flesh" agreement establishes the central plot point. Antonio's life is put at risk, setting up the trial scene in Act 4.
- **Dramatic Irony:** Antonio's confidence that his ships will return safely builds suspense, as the audience anticipates the potential disaster.
- **Theme Development:** Key themes are introduced early: **revenge vs. mercy**, **religious prejudice**, **appearance vs. reality** (Shylock's polite behavior), and **risk/uncertainty**.

- **Character Motivations:** Shylock's monologue outlines his deep-seated reasons for seeking revenge, justifying his later refusal to show mercy.

Character Sketches

PART IV

Shylock

THE COMPLEX ANTAGONIST

Calculated

Resentful

Cunning

Victimized

In this scene, Shylock is established as a complex character. He is driven by a desire for revenge, aiming to “*feed fat the ancient grudge*.” He is clever and patient, hiding his trap behind the phrase “*merry sport*.”

However, Shakespeare also depicts Shylock as a victim. His explanation of being insulted and spit upon by Antonio on the Rialto, along with the line “*suffrance is the badge of all our tribe*,” highlights the prejudice he faces in Venice.



Antonio

THE FLAWED FOIL

Loyal Friend

Overconfident

Prejudiced

Melancholic

Antonio is shown as a devoted friend who is willing to risk his life and credit to support Bassanio. His generosity is his defining positive trait.

However, he displays significant flaws, including religious prejudice and arrogance. He openly admits he is likely to spit on and insult Shylock again, showing no remorse. His overconfidence in his business affairs leads him to sign the risky bond.

🕒 Core Themes

PART V



Revenge

Shylock's desire to satisfy his "ancient grudge" drives the scene's conflict. The bond is a personal vendetta disguised as a legal contract.



Prejudice

The dialogue highlights mutual hostility: Antonio's public insults and Shylock's deep resentment of Christians show the division in Venice.



Usury vs. Charity

The contrast between Antonio's interest-free lending and Shylock's business model creates an economic and moral debate between the characters.



Appearance vs. Reality

This is shown through Shylock's "kindness" in offering the "merry bond," which hides his intention to take Antonio's life.

≡ Literary Devices

Shakespeare uses various literary devices in this scene to enhance the drama and characterize the participants:

Literary Device	Example from Text	Dramatic Effect
Aside	<i>"I hate him for he is a Christian..."</i>	Reveals Shylock’s private thoughts and motivations directly to the audience.
Dramatic Irony	<i>"This is kind I offer."</i>	Creates suspense, as the audience knows Shylock's offer is a trap.
Metaphor	<i>"A goodly apple rotten at the heart."</i>	Develops the theme of appearance vs. reality.
Biblical Allusion	<i>Jacob and Laban story</i>	Highlights Shylock's attempt to justify his business practices using scripture.
Repetition	<i>"Three thousand ducats..."</i>	Emphasizes Shylock's focus on the financial details of the agreement.
Animal Imagery	<i>"dog", "cur", "spit upon my Jewish gaberdine"</i>	Illustrates the degradation and insults Shylock experiences in Venice.

∞ Key Quotations

PART VII

"I hate him for he is a Christian; But more for that in low simplicity he lends out money gratis..."

This quotation reveals the two main reasons for Shylock's hatred: religious conflict and economic competition. It establishes his motivations before he meets with Antonio.

"The devil can cite Scripture for his purpose! An evil soul producing holy witness is like a villain with a smiling cheek..."

Antonio warns Bassanio about hypocrisy, comparing Shylock to a rotten apple. Despite this warning, Antonio still signs the bond, highlighting his overconfidence.

"For suffrance is the badge of all our tribe. You call me misbeliever, cut-throat dog, and spit upon my Jewish gaberdine..."

This speech explains Shylock's resentment, detailing the insults and abuse he faces. It provides context for his later refusal to show mercy.

"If I can catch him once upon the hip, I will feed fat the ancient grudge I bear him."

Using a wrestling metaphor, Shylock expresses his intention to use the law to trap Antonio, highlighting the calculated nature of his revenge.

"Go with me to a notary, seal me there your single bond; and, in a merry sport..."

This passage introduces the "pound of flesh" condition as a "merry sport," showing how Shylock masks his intentions to secure the agreement.

🔖 Revision & Exam Tips

PART VIII

🔔 How to Score Well in ICSE

- 1 Context:** Always identify the speaker, the listener, and the circumstances surrounding the quote before answering context questions.
- 2 Keywords:** Incorporate terms from the play, such as “*ancient grudge*,” “*merry bond*,” “*suffrance*,” and “*usance*.”
- 3 Literary Devices:** Identify and explain the purpose of devices like dramatic irony or metaphors in your responses.
- 4 Dramatic Irony:** Pay attention to questions about irony, particularly Antonio’s confidence versus Shylock’s intentions.
- 5 Structure:** Organize longer answers with a brief introduction, a detailed middle section, and a clear concluding statement.

Interactive Revision Tracker

Use this checklist to track your progress. Your selections will be saved automatically.

- ☐ Understand the reasons for Shylock’s hatred of Antonio
- ☐ Explain the terms and significance of the “pound of flesh” bond
- ☐ Recall the Biblical story of Jacob and Laban and its relevance
- ☐ Analyze the contrast between Antonio and Shylock
- ☐ Study the character sketch of Shylock (victim vs. villain)
- ☐ Study the character sketch of Antonio (loyalty vs. prejudice)
- ☐ Identify examples of dramatic irony in the scene

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